

Stringout Audio Eventbrite

William Salvi: [00:00:00] Or an, uh

Kevin Hartz: An amoeba or other bacteria I think

William Salvi: they did say bacterial, right?

Kevin Hartz: Oh, bacterial.

William Salvi: I think they

Julia Hartz: did

William Salvi: say bacterial. Yeah, it is bacterial.

Julia Hartz: Heavy.

Kevin Hartz: That's easy though.

Julia Hartz: I keep, I think I've said that like 17 times. It's bacterial.

Kevin Hartz: Oh, sorry. You

Julia Hartz: have to eat the thing.

Kevin Hartz: Well, you, that's, then you just take antibiotics if it's too long.

William Salvi: Yeah.

Kevin Hartz: But we all take too many antibiotics.

William Salvi: I don't remember the last time I did.

Kevin Hartz: That's good, because- Knock

William Salvi: on wood, I don't, I, I-

Kevin Hartz: We're building up bacterial resistant- I take like... Yeah ... strains around the world.

William Salvi: I'm not a big fan of like- I'm not against it, I just, I just try to avoid it until I need something.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah. Well, your daughter, you know, as sh- like, through those ages, like, over the next 10 years, that's when they get all sorts of, like, bugs. Yeah, yeah. And you have to decide, like, ear infection, do I give her antibiotics or- Right ... you know, let her ear bone- How, where,

William Salvi: where did you fall on the spectrum of, like, how often you went to the doctor to go get that stuff or-

Kevin Hartz: Well, I felt like-

let's let it ride? I felt like we did it probably too much. Um- Yeah.

William Salvi: At the beginning probably. Definitely with our first. Yeah.

Kevin Hartz: Uh-

William Salvi: How [00:01:00] old are your first two, did you

Kevin Hartz: say? But our first was susceptible to ear infections. She had a num- like, four of them or five of them. Yeah. And they- And if you don't treat

William Salvi: them-

Kevin Hartz: They can be a huge pain in the ass, yeah

if you don't treat them, her eardrum burst once, and you have, like- Damage ... pus, blood coming out of her ear. Yeah. And I was just like, "Oh my God, poor baby."

William Salvi: Geez.

Kevin Hartz: So-

William Salvi: Ear infections can cause some serious pain, too.

Julia Hartz: Yeah.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah.

William Salvi: Yeah. She's 18 now. I'm glad it cleared itself, yeah. She's the oldest?

Kevin Hartz: Yeah.

William Salvi: How is that with, like, daughters going...

I'm just curious, 'cause I, I hear dads talk about that a lot with their daughters. Like, "Oh, my daughter's a teenager," and... M- I, I just think it's sometimes

Julia Hartz: overblown, but

William Salvi: I don't know

Julia Hartz: The girls are, they're incredibly loving and caretaking toward their father. At the same time, they're incredibly dismissive and vicious toward him.

They have an- That's why you get new ones ... understanding with me. Yeah. Like, so he's, like, kind of like a puppy that, like, runs into the wrong place at the wrong time and gets, like, swatted out of the way. Yeah.

William Salvi: But you still love the puppy. Yeah.

Julia Hartz: Yeah, yeah. And I'm, like, the battered she-wolf [00:02:00] that walks in and is just, like, gives a look to the girls and activates them.

But, like, they try to come after me, but I kind of, I'm the one swatting them. You get in, yeah. So I think it's basically, like, they're learning from me and then passing it down. And he's not, um, wrong when he says, like, I could mitigate their mistreatment of him. I just don't choose to all the time. But some- It's funny

but sometimes I'll send a group text and I'll be like, "We all need to lay off Dad." Yeah. Like, we gotta give him a, a little minute, 'cause he's the only guy in the house.

William Salvi: Okay. Well, we are good to go in here, so whenever you wanna get started. Sweet. And then, uh, when I said 70, let's switch it to 60 minutes so you can tell me, um, when, uh, you can just stop me whenever there's a natural break- I feel so recorded ... and then I'll start wrapping up. I

Julia Hartz: know, well, it's like five. Okay, sounds good.

William Salvi: Thank you. Are we recording right now?

Kevin Hartz: Oh, where do we look, by the way?

Julia Hartz: Yeah, we're

William Salvi: recording. Oh, look at me the whole time. Okay, good. Please.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah.

William Salvi: All right. So I don't do a, I don't do any intro, and I've been, I've been, like, asking. This is the very first episode [00:03:00] that we've done where it's a microphone in my face.

Mm. Yeah. How exciting is that? That's

Kevin Hartz: exciting. W- would it happen before? You're gonna be okay with that. I'm trying to remember, was it a- So we were-

William Salvi: I am okay with it. Our previous episodes, I, we would call it, like, a show, like a produced show. Mm-hmm. Okay? Versus a podcast.

Julia Hartz: Yeah.

William Salvi: But now we're kind of veering towards the podcast, 'cause I get all these very smart people and accomplished people, and then we'd cut the show down.

We'd film them for two hours. We'd cut the show down, and I'd have a 25-minute show. And I liked the episodes, but it would be cutting out so much content So now I want it to be more conversational and get more-

Producer: Yeah ...

William Salvi: in depth, so. And I feel like the mics give, like, a vibe-

Producer: Yeah ...

William Salvi: as a host, so. I

Producer: like it.

William Salvi: But, but let's start, so Julia Hartz and Kevin Hartz.

Yes. We've talked about this. You, you get your name confused with Kevin Hart-

Kevin Hartz: Kevin Hart,

William Salvi: right ... a lot, and that's a bummer. So, or not a bummer. I don't know. What would, how would you describe it?

Kevin Hartz: Well, it, I mean, the worst part, uh, is when you, you know, have, like, a, a driver at the airport with a sign that says Kevin Hart, and [00:04:00] you're coming down, you know, the escalator or something, and you see it, and you re- realize that that driver thinks Kevin Hart- Yeah

is gonna be his ride. And then your mom's. Yeah. And he's so excited. He's so excited, and then I have to go up, go out there and ruin his day.

William Salvi: Yeah.

Julia Hartz: And we, we stand back, like, 10 feet, uh, my daughter and I, and we just, it's like we watch the crust fallen situation. We just die laughing. Yeah. So we're very happy about it.

William Salvi: I love it. That's fun. But okay, so what I wanna do before we get started into Eventbrite or Zoom or just generally leadership founder stories, uh, can you give me both, we'll start with Kevin, a quick Spark Note, SparkNotes version of how you two eventually converged and met on Eventbrite? So give me a quick version of before that and what you were doing, and then go to Julia afterwards.

Julia Hartz: SparkNote? Like CliffNote? Hey, guys. Just a quick jump in.

Really sorry to bother you. Um, Kevin, could you push your microphone down a touch? I'm sorry. I didn't realize I was blocking your face.

William Salvi: That

[00:05:00] is perfect. Thank you. Sorry about that.

Julia Hartz: Is my fan okay? 'Cause it's doing like a Beyonce thing. Yeah, it, it's not loud.

I like it.

William Salvi: You think- It's okay? ... you think the first part was good, though? We're, we're, we're good, right? Other than that- The first part was great. Uh, first part was, first part was dynamite.

Kevin Hartz: Can I tell my other, uh- ... Kevin Hart story?

William Salvi: Please.

Kevin Hartz: Okay, great. Um, let me

Other: jump in. I-

Uh-oh. Wait. Could

William Salvi: I- Oh, no. Aw, no. Could I keep mine on? Oh, boy, I didn't mean to say that. I'm

Other: gonna be like a sweaty pig. It's, it, it- Yeah, we'll- We can fix it in post

William Salvi: I don't wanna tell them how to do their job, but I, I would prefer them to be on

Kevin Hartz: Has to be silent

Julia Hartz: But mine's kind of aggressive.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah,

Julia Hartz: yours is very aggressive Like, mine's doing like a full on path

Kevin Hartz: Yeah, you could turn it down to just one

Julia Hartz: Yeah

William Salvi: Mine's-

Kevin Hartz: And turn off the- Mine is

William Salvi: like

Kevin Hartz: a- But no, no, no, don't change it.

Now-

William Salvi: That makes it not move on the right, so that's actually the one that

Kevin Hartz: you probably want. Yeah Yeah, so go down to one Probably

Julia Hartz: we want

Kevin Hartz: it- Oh, God ...

Julia Hartz: there, right?

Kevin Hartz: Thought it was gonna fall.

Julia Hartz: How's that?[00:06:00]

Producer: I think that'll be good. Brittany's just gonna listen on headphones to make sure we're not picking it up, but-

Julia Hartz: Okay ... should

Producer: be

Julia Hartz: okay. Thanks.

This is why we can't have nice things

William Salvi: I know. Yeah

So now I see my ankles, but they saw them before. Yeah, if I did this, it would not be ... That's not fine.

Julia Hartz: No, and also I don't think that the socks are really distracting 'cause it just looks like a shadow.

William Salvi: Yeah.

Hey friends, I'm sorry. I do kind of hear the fans when I put the headphones on. Mm-hmm. I do think we should turn them-

Julia Hartz: For like ever I

Kevin Hartz: did that.

I am so sor- I did that.

Julia Hartz: Forever? Sorry about that. It's okay We're really honest. Okay. It's okay. We got

Kevin Hartz: you. All right.

William Salvi: We're

Julia Hartz: gonna, we're gonna

William Salvi: just have to go through

Kevin Hartz: it. Sweat it out. Um- I mean, you know what I'm gonna do Should we, uh- I can, I can, I can We could take our shirts off I can turn the comment Why don't we take our shirts

Julia Hartz: off?

We won't look at your butt when you get up. Yeah, start

Kevin Hartz: doing shirtless. Shirtless and pant-less.

Julia Hartz: I'm into it. Maybe

Kevin Hartz: we should just turn them off. Let's just see how sweaty... Let's, like, make it a sauna.

Julia Hartz: Feel like we just got ourselves in trouble. I'm gonna,

Kevin Hartz: I'm gonna- Oh, it sounds... It's so much clear... I mean, it's so- Oh, yeah

quiet now. It's [00:07:00] so quiet

William Salvi: now.

Julia Hartz: All right.

William Salvi: Yeah. Suspiciously quiet. Nice. All right, so-

Julia Hartz: Okay, let's go

William Salvi: Oh, someone's here.

Julia Hartz: Yeah.

Kevin Hartz: Okay, here she comes.

William Salvi: I turned it off. It's okay. You did? Yeah, yeah. Sorry. No, it's okay.

Julia Hartz: Hi, sorry.

William Salvi: And then I'm gonna turn it-

Kevin Hartz: Sorry, everyone's apologizing.

William Salvi: Thank God.

Other: No they're not.

William Salvi: Um, we're

Kevin Hartz: gonna- Can I tell my other Kevin Hart story?

William Salvi: Yeah, please. I think we're probably still recording, I assume. Yeah, we're still recording. Okay.

Kevin Hartz: My other Kevin Hart story is that, uh, I have a f- friend over at Founders Fund, Delian. He's, he's kind of a punk. Uh, and he was leading this investment in Eight Sleep, the mattresses that I absolutely love. This is not, like, an Eight Sleep commercial, but we have it.

William Salvi: Yeah, Kevin, are you sponsored by them?

Kevin Hartz: Yeah. This is sponsored by Eight Sleep. Um, and Delian reaches out to me and he's like, "Kevin, I'm so excited we're investing together in, in Eight Sleep." And I said, "Uh, uh, n- I... No, I'm not." I'm like, "I'm not invested. I... You know, I'm not sure what you're talking about." And Delian figured [00:08:00] out that it was Kevin Hart, but he was so embarrassed, uh, that he ended up, like, inviting me in to invest.

So we invested in Eight Sleep that way.

Other: God,

William Salvi: that's amazing. So you were, you were- Plug in Eight Sleep. H Sleep?

Kevin Hartz: Eight. Eight. Eight, Eight Sleep. Eight Sleep. Eight Sleep. Got it.

William Salvi: Okay.

Kevin Hartz: Which, H Shleep.

William Salvi: I

Kevin Hartz: don't know. Do you know what an Eight Sleep mattress is?

William Salvi: No, I

Julia Hartz: don't. Oh, it's amazing.

William Salvi: Yeah.

Julia Hartz: Oh my God. So, so- I assume

William Salvi: it does the, the, the-

Julia Hartz: Body temperature regulation.

Okay. It does, it does some monitoring, but it is... For us, it's, it's magical because each side of the bed can be a different temperature, and our whole

family has them. So you can, you know, whoever runs cold can have a heated mattress. Whoever runs hot... Like, I go down to the very-

William Salvi: Yeah, yeah ...

Julia Hartz: depths of ice, but then I, I calibrate it to actually warm up through the night, and so it's quite lovely.

William Salvi: I love it.

Julia Hartz: Mm-hmm.

William Salvi: Mattresses are key.

Julia Hartz: Mm-hmm.

Kevin Hartz: Well, 90 degrees and humid here in New York, if you're in an apartment or [00:09:00] flat without, uh- Air conditioning ... air conditioning. Oh,

Julia Hartz: right. We don't have air conditioning in San Francisco, so this- Right ... is, like, your only form of temperature regulation. Do you not? No. No.

Kevin Hartz: It's just- You

William Salvi: mean, like, generally, like in San- Like,

Julia Hartz: no one has AC ... San

Kevin Hartz: Francisco is traditionally foggy most of the time. It's,

Julia Hartz: it's just cool. Nature is air conditioning. Right. We have, like, seven sunny days a year, but those seven sunny days are real brutal.

William Salvi: Yeah.

Julia Hartz: So.

Kevin Hartz: It's-

William Salvi: I like San Fran. I'm gonna... I, I don't know why.

I just, I think it's a great metropolitan area It got a lot, it, it, it had kinda like a moment like Chicago where people just started, like, crapping on San Fran, and I thought-

Kevin Hartz: Literally.

William Salvi: Yeah. That was part of the- It was

Julia Hartz: real. Yeah. I actually thought the headlines- I think that's a- ... weren't doing- Yeah ... enough to describe how terrible it was for- Was

Kevin Hartz: it?

about a year

Julia Hartz: and a half It really

Kevin Hartz: was. We, we had one to two people dying a day from fentanyl. Oh, geez. Yes. Um, it, like, it was a horrific period that, um, I kinda give the kudos to, uh, Daniel Lurie, our relatively new mayor, uh, and Sam Altman for, [00:10:00] like, driving and starting the AI kind of gold rush that's m- swinging things the other direction.

Julia Hartz: S- so- I, I think what people misunderstand about San Francisco is that it actually was built on this idea of boom and bust cycles, and so, you know, the Gold- it was known as the Gold Rush City, so it's actually pretty well tuned to be a place where people come, uh, temporarily, put their, their stuff down, make their fortune, and then leave.

And so, you know, the headlines that were talking about people leaving were very real. We felt it personally. A lot of our friends left the city, they left the state. But the underpinning of San Francisco is actually tuned to that, and so you never wanna bet against a city that's actually evol- learned to adapt and iterate and evolve as quickly as San Francisco.

And another th- another thing that people don't know and don't talk about is even in that very dark time, which was, it felt like we were living in a, like, for a minute it felt like São Paulo. Like it was really, you couldn't drive anywhere 'cause [00:11:00] you would get, your car would get broken into or you'd get carjacked.

There was, there was that moment when it was sort of lawless. But now that we're back to a functioning city, what people don't realize is that in the depths and darkest times of COVID, uh, there were people that were starting to work and live together in a little neighborhood called Hayes Valley, um, and I think you, you called it Cerebral Valley, where they were starting to build the, the AI companies of today and, and sort of living and working in, in this almost commune through that crazy time.

And it, it sort of happened under the radar, but it was like a one-block radius, and I just think that's so emblematic of San Francisco and the builder culture. And so we're very long San Francisco, but I also think that the reporting on it was almost, it was almost, like, sort of too surface and wasn't actually getting to the root- Oh, that's interesting

of what was going on.

William Salvi: Yeah.

Julia Hartz: Yeah. '

William Salvi: Cause I would s- 'cause Chicago has parallels there where people just use it as a political talking point. There's v- a lot of truth to [00:12:00] what, uh, some of the complaints were, but, and problems that existed in Chicago, and they still exist today, but I do think it was used in the national media as, you know, like, "Well, look at gun violence in Chicago," and so- Right

then they just point to it. But it's not a top 20 city per capita of violent crime. But I digress. I'm a Chic- I'm long Chicago as well- Yeah ... but they need to get their shit together. Um, but I, I asked this earlier before we turned off the fans and I started, like, beading sweat down my back. Mm-hmm. But, um, I wanna know before you two met, essentially, like a quick SparkNotes.

I, I don't know how to define SparkNotes. Just a quick version of your story prior to meeting.

Julia Hartz: You're aging yourself with the SparkNotes, and then I'm gonna age myself and say that I think it's the modern-day CliffsNotes, right? Yeah. Is that what it is?

Kevin Hartz: Same difference.

Julia Hartz: Okay, cool. Cool.

William Salvi: Yeah, and now it's just AI.

Great. You just put text in AI- Mm-hmm ... and it, it, like, summarizes it for you.

Julia Hartz: Totally. Yeah. Yeah, yeah.

William Salvi: Summarize, yeah.

Julia Hartz: Um, so I grew up in a small town called Santa Cruz, which is a little, little beach town, um, home of The Lost Boys- [00:13:00] Okay ... great movie. Yeah. Uh, and Jack O'Neill. And I went to college in Southern California, started working in Hollywood, and, uh, met Kevin at a wedding.

My, my first boss at MTV married his classmate from Stanford, so it was sort of like sheiks and geeks down the aisle, and we, we, we, we bridged the gap, and- So

William Salvi: you were a TV producer?

Julia Hartz: I was, I was in television development.

William Salvi: Nice.

Julia Hartz: I worked on the first movie, or the first... Sorry, I worked on Jackass. Uh-

William Salvi: So this was, like, a nice moment in MTV.

Julia Hartz: It was. It was the beginning of the end, I think. I was

William Salvi: about to say, that was the beginning of

Julia Hartz: when it probably started that- It was the beginning of the end, yeah ... fall of it Yeah, so I worked, I worked in the group that discovered Jackass. I was actually an intern when they sent their pilot in, and I got to be a part of that journey, and it was incredible.

And then I went on to FX, and actually was there during the beginning of John Landgraf's era, which is, you know, really just this epic era [00:14:00] of content, um, and creativity, and I worked on The Shield, and Rescue Me, and, um- Nice ... Nip/Tuck, and so-

William Salvi: Nip/Tuck.

Julia Hartz: I know. Hot show. What a cult show.

William Salvi: Hot show.

Julia Hartz: What a- Yeah. And Ryan Murphy's early work.

William Salvi: Hot show. Yeah. Yeah, I remember

Julia Hartz: that one. Yeah. So I was very fortunate, and yet also when I met Kevin, it became abundantly clear that my industry as I knew it was dying, and the next era of innovation and prosper was about to happen in his industry.

Kevin Hartz: Well, I mean, at that time in the 2000s, that was, you know, when Keith Javid and Steve started- Uh, YouTube, uh, in the, the mid 2000s, and, you know, that took off, um, you know, incredibly fast, and that was, you know, the kind of parallel universe.

Like, I was over in the Valley, um, you know, meanwhile, while dating her at, [00:15:00] um, when she was at MTV and then FX. And, you know, things were changing so dramatically, and there was a lot of questions going on. And of course, you know, like Hollywood has been inexorably changed now. Um, content development, m- you know, the new studios, uh, Amazon and Netflix, and, um, it's, it's almost been entirely remade.

But maybe I should go back a bit or forward? I can go either way.

William Salvi: No, that's perfect. I actually ... No, I, I ... Just, just for the sake of time, I g- I, 'cause I could dive into ... I, I mentioned this on the, the call that we had together. I could go deep into your, like, pre-story, but since there's two of you and I wanna talk more so about you two working together- Mm

and, and, uh, building this company. But I wanna know, like, how the impetus of you guys, like, deciding to work together. So y- were you dating? Were you engaged? Were you already married? And then how did- Yeah ... the idea of

Eventbrite come about? And then on top of that, so I'm married. Um, I [00:16:00] don't know if I would be able to work in that capacity with my wife.

Mm-hmm. I don't feel bad for saying that, but, like, I think that would probably be true for a lot of people. I work with my brother. Um- Mm-hmm ... and I love working with my brother, but I don't think I could work for my other, work with my other brothers. And, um, and it does create, like, a super unique relationship-

Mm-hmm

William Salvi: 'cause you're in this, like, mission together, but then you also have the relationship, for example, with my brother. I'm his brother, and we're best friends in that sense. But I'm interested in how this all came about- Yeah ... and how you started this and why, like, if you're dating or ... Tell me. I mean, I'm-

Kevin Hartz: Well, I, I think we have-

I wanna know more ... a heart connection 'cause you work with your sibling, and I work with my wife, Julia, and, you know, that is a special relationship because it's only a very small minority. I don't know the percentages. Maybe someday they'll do some kind of DNA a- analysis and find there's some, like, connection, genetic connection to who could actually work together, but it's a very small percentage of, of founders [00:17:00] that could actually work with their siblings or work with their spouses.

Um, my parents I always say, like, would've strangled each other, but they were married 50 years, and- Right ... you know, the whole nine yards. In terms of, like, reversing things now back to how we started, um, you know, Julia, when I met, she was at MTV, and I was working on a money remittance business called Xoom, X-O-O-M.

It's a adjunct to PayPal. We were the first developers on the PayPal API, and this, I say this now because it's gonna be important for Eventbrite. Um- Zoom eventually went public in 2013 and was acquired by PayPal in 2015. But, um, you know, that the company had worked out and we, we saw kinda PayPal, you know, this is pre-Stripe, as a payments platform, and we were looking at what other problem areas were there.

And, uh, [00:18:00] ticketing was a fundamentally broken area. And so, you know, ticketing was that area that, that we honed in on. Um, I, you know, when I had moved to the board of Zoom, um, you know, I now had time, free time to go

and figure this out and start something new. And Julia moved up to the Bay Area. We'd just gotten engaged, and that's when we decided to start Eventbrite and pursue the ticketing market together.

William Salvi: Were you worried about it at all? Like, that it would, that it would ruin the relationship- Well- ... if you pursued this together?

Julia Hartz: Here's my recollection. I was pretty burned out at the ripe age of 25, uh, from the Hollywood thing, and I just had this feeling like I was on the wrong side of the equation. And I think the feeling or the intuition came from being able to really experience over two years of, of dating, you know, what was going on in Silicon [00:19:00] Valley.

And I, funny enough, even though I grew up in the Bay Area, I had missed the first bubble. So watching, coming up to San Francisco, we'd take these walks on the weekend. Kevin had a loft in SoMa, and we'd walk down, you know, Fourth Street, and he'd point out all these empty buildings and the companies that used to be in those buildings.

There's

Kevin Hartz: Webvan- This is after the dotcom crash. So this is the 2000s when, you know, in the n- 1990s you had this massive run-up of- Mm-hmm ... of internet businesses. Sorry.

Julia Hartz: And so, you know, he was like my little historian, is showing, guiding, guiding me through what w- what did happen. And then we were comparing notes.

I mean, I was fortunate enough to be on the cutting edge of the best content studio, I think today, writ large, and see that beginning. But he was also starting to see things like The first YouTube video and, and we kind of put our, the two realities together. And it became clear to [00:20:00] me that I was ready to make the leap to Silicon Valley one way or the other.

But I am more safe, I play it more safe than Kevin does. And so I got a job offer from a startup cable network called Current TV that was just being started. Uh, some of the people involved were like Al Gore, and it was citizen journalism. Nice. And I felt like, "Okay, here we are. I'm parlaying my skills." You know, I grew up as a ballerina, so I'm like really good at like finding the goal and then going and doing.

And I'm like, "I'm parlaying my, my skills into this new thing," and it's in the Bay Area, and we're engaged. We're gonna start our life up here near our families.

Kevin Hartz: It was 60,000 a year.

Julia Hartz: Yeah. I think it was less actually. I think I was maybe making 80, and that was a lot. Mm-hmm. And I, I, uh, I was offered 50. And I remember bringing that to Kevin and, and being like, "Do you think I should do it?"

I mean, it feels like I should just jump on this because that allows all the things that I'm looking for." And he was like, "Time out." [00:21:00] Like, and all I remember is him saying something like Sure, you could go work on someone else's startup and make way less than you're worth, or... And then that's where, like for me, the tape gets cut.

Like, I do not remember you pitching Eventbrite to me. I just remember the next scene is, like, I'm moving out of my 42nd floor window office in Century City, which was Nakatomi Plaza in Die Hard. It was the f- it's the Fox Plaza- ... building. And I'm driving up the coast, and then quite literally, with all my belongings, my brother was with me, I think.

And then the next day we're literally pushing sawhorses and plywood into a windowless phone closet in a warehouse in Potrero Hill, which is a neighborhood, like a design district neighborhood in, uh, San Francisco. And I'm thinking, "What if he's crazy?" Like, literally having a very delayed thought. We're already engaged.

Yeah. It would be [00:22:00] very- How long- ... awkward ...

William Salvi: had you been dating pr- prior to this?

Julia Hartz: Two years. Two years, okay. But it had been long distance. Got it. So we moved in together, we started Eventbrite together, we got married, and we had our first baby all within 18 months.

Other: Wow.

Julia Hartz: And, you know, I had that fleeting thought of what if he's crazy?

And, like, I can definitely say he's definitely crazy, but there's, like a good crazy and a bad crazy, and thankfully I found my partner in a good crazy. And that's w- I,

Kevin Hartz: I'm sometimes bad crazy.

Julia Hartz: Yeah. No, but more you fall off onto- Aren't we all sometimes? That's kind of good, yeah ... the good crazy. Yeah. Yeah, ultimately ends in a good place, obviously.

Um, but we, but we started Eventbrite in this tiny little... Literally we had this, this free office space. The landlord gave us the, the phone closet.

Kevin Hartz: Well, he was, he was our, uh, landlord when we started Zoom. And, um, Mark Pincus, who started Tribe, was right next to us. And, um, what else was in there? A company called Trulia that merged with Zillow.

Mm-hmm. Flixster. Um, it- uh, Flixster, which was early- I [00:23:00] remember Flixster. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. It was like images, right? Yeah. Yeah. Yeah, it was a great group of founders, and the, the owner of the building was this amazing person. Um, and so he, when we told him we were starting something new, he's like, "You've gotta come into our building," and gave us the space.

William Salvi: Did you all always want to be entrepreneurs? Like, did you have... It sounds like you... Sorry. Sounds like you had more of, like a, it kinda came up and you were doing the, the MTV, and you were in content and production, and then this kinda came up and you jumped- Yeah ... into it. But did you, did either of you have a feeling that you were gonna do your own thing one day and start a business and- I, I,

Julia Hartz: I don't like when people say, "Oh, I just fell into it," because that's really, um, aggravating to hear from people who found success.

Um-

William Salvi: My bad. I didn't mean to-

Julia Hartz: No, no, no. I'm just saying, so I'm not gonna say, I'm not gonna say, "Oh, I was just hanging out and Kevin kind of, like, forced me into it." Right. More so, I think that I, I definitely did not think of myself as an

entrepreneur. I was [00:24:00] not the kid who had the lemonade stand growing up.

I was a ballerina. I knew how to work hard, take direction, make adjustments, and go from there. So I have always thought of myself as a pretty good operator. Um, but I chose this, obviously, even though I can't remember the point at which I said yes. I chose to take the leap and see what was on the other side.

I can tell you that if you, if a person like me meets a person like him, who ha- who doesn't quite literally have the chip that says, "This may not work," and he has this amazing way of sort of casually, like, dropping breadcrumbs, you know. Like, "Ooh, just try this and see what happens." It's like a, it's a magical combination, and I don't think you have to be romantically involved.

I think it can happen between-

William Salvi: That's how my brother is with us, yeah ...

Julia Hartz: yeah, exactly. It's like these, these, these complimentary- Good ... skillsets.

William Salvi: Well, not the romantic

Julia Hartz: part. Uh, yeah.

William Salvi: Yeah, that, that's where I was wondering- And then-

We took 23andMe, we're actually siblings. Yeah, yeah. It's, like, really awkward.

Yeah. Yeah, yeah.

Julia Hartz: Um, no, but I think that, that happened, but we both intentionally [00:25:00] chose it, and then, and then through the hard work and the focus, it's, it worked out. But I think, I don't, your story's different, because I do think that you had more of an entrepreneurial-

Kevin Hartz: I, I mean, I, I did have-

Julia Hartz: Thing ...

Kevin Hartz: more entrepreneurial actions in my past, uh, but I also grew up in a kind of WASPy middle class area in, in the Bay Area.

Um, and so- Were they,

William Salvi: were your parents entrepreneurs?

Kevin Hartz: No, not. My dad, uh, is a retired attorney. My mom was in real estate, uh, commercial real estate and, um, and a tiger mom, so maybe that's part of it. What's

William Salvi: a tiger mom?

Kevin Hartz: A, a tiger mom is, uh, a mom that, like, stays on her children and ensures that they get into Harvard or Stanford or, you know, kind of rides them all through, uh, high school.

I, I, I say that in a, a kind of negative tone because it's, it, it's been negatively defined, but, you know, my mom, like, [00:26:00] guided me in a, in a n- nice way towards- Do you view it- ... high achieving ...

William Salvi: not negatively, but do you view it as kinda like a, "Oh, I wish I've had a little more freedom to..."

Kevin Hartz: No, not at all. Okay.

Yeah. I, it, it, I pl- I had plenty of freedom and I would also say, though, I wasn't, like, what I saw as, like, a typical founder, like, you know, a, you know, with the PayPal example, Max Levchin is from the Ukraine and fled during Chernobyl, if I remember the story correctly, and came to Chicago and dumpster dived for computer parts and, um, you know, and then comes out to the West and meets Peter Thiel and starts PayPal, and the rest is history.

Um, and so, you know, maybe I have some degree of, of imposter syndrome arou- around it, but, um, whether it was Zoom or whether it was Eventbrite, I just had so much fun building and, you know, we were obsessed with the product. We [00:27:00] were obsessed with what we were doing, and that's the, the main part of it. It's like, I can't believe, you know, I get to do this all the time, and it was fun.

Now, there was always some difficult stages to it, but, uh, it was an amazing experience in, in both those cases.

William Salvi: How did the... Tell me about maybe, like, 'cause I think on the headlines, right, like, people see the headlines of, like, husband and wife, like, is at Eventbrite and- Mm-hmm ... sold for, you know, \$500 million.

Like, it's, like, such a great headline and story. It really is. And congrats to you both on it, but, uh, but, like, what d- what was a moment where the lines blurred between, like, quite literally lovers and business partners where it was really difficult? And you just mentioned whereas you had a, a child, you started this company, you move.

Like, those are major life milestones. So it's, it would probably be difficult, like, emotionally just to go through all of this, and then to go through all of it together while you have the mission of the company, but then you also have the mission, so to speak, of a relationship. So how did the lines blur?

Were there any experiences where you were [00:28:00] worried that it would, it would all crumble?

Julia Hartz: Oh, I was, uh- We

really, uh, very naturally embraced it, having it all be a part of our lives. I mean, I think having, finding that, that shared interest and passion around live experiences. You know, Kevin came to it from an idea of how to democratize an in- industry just that he'd done with, with, uh, money transfer and, and really making something possible that wasn't possible before, better, faster, cheaper.

Me coming to it from an idea of almost an anthropological study around how people connect and, and what happens when they're in these experiences, and the analogy to it being, like, another media format. Um, and then our third co-founder, who we have to mention 'cause he's such a huge, huge part of this, Renaud Visage, our co-founding CTO, really having a passion around turning your talents and passion into profit, um, which came [00:29:00] to fruition during the first financial crisis because we, we ran through that as well.

I think that you, you find this common ground and, and we felt incred- and do feel incredibly fortunate to be able to build a life around that. I mean, our, our People would always ask us, "How do you turn it off?" And finally, I just started saying like, "We don't wanna turn it off." It is such a, an advantage to be able to go home and, and have an idea, and turn right to your co-founder and tell them that idea, or to problem solve over dinner.

The thing that changed for us pretty quickly was that we had our, we had our first daughter pretty early on, and we ... I think that was a huge part of what allowed us to, to self-regulate and balance, which was we, we had this ... I think, you know, we had a core principle around outsourcing your non-core competencies, and because of that, we figured out how to really raise our first child as like she, she deserved our full attention when we were not working on Eventbrite, [00:30:00] when we were home, and everything else needed to be done by other people, which actually was like an equalizer.

Kevin Hartz: Did you catch the outsource your non-core competencies comment? That just means, like, you know, if, if maybe laundry or, uh, shopping is not your core competency, send it out. You gotta outsource it. Cleaning or ... Uh, you know, and, and it's like an arbitrage of, of value. You know, if you're worth X amount per hour, why work on things, um, that are much less than that?

And if you can then outsource those, it gives you more time to focus on what you love to do and you're, where you're creating the most value, as well as, like, your family and friends and so on. There's, there's fun stuff. You don't have to quantify everything.

Julia Hartz: And it wasn't fancy. It was, like, you know, just literally taking our laundry to, like, an outsource place- Yeah, I- I-

and, and figuring out, you know- I understand. You're like, "We need to"- Now we're, like, completely ... "we need to

William Salvi: allocate our time appropriately- Yes ... for [00:31:00] not just our family, but for our work, for ourselves."

Julia Hartz: Yeah. And we were really passionate about that because we wanted her to know that she was a core part of the team, but she also felt like she was a par- and I'm talking about our daughter.

She also felt like she was a part of Eventbrite. So if you asked our first two daughters what, like, you know, like, what their lives were like, inevitably Eventbrite would come up. All their best friends at Eventbrite would come up. They came to the office all the time, and we just built our lives and the company, um-

Producer: In unison

Julia Hartz: in unison. And I think, I think a lot of people overthink that and sort of fre- like, kinda, uh, stress themselves out over that notion. But it was really sweet and productive and thoughtful and focused. I think the harder thing for us was when I took over as CEO and Kevin stepped back- To focus on other things.

That was the harder part for us because we were so used to working together for 10 years that the next 10 years of not working [00:32:00] side by side literally, nobody wanted to sit next to us, so we'd always be seatmate, you know, tablemates in like the open floor plan. And, uh- But- ... that was really difficult and challenging.

Kevin Hartz: But our game, uh, our kind of game plan working side by side was a divide and conquer sort of strategy is like that there are areas that I would focus on, like product, and areas that Julia would focus on, like finance. And we had very strict rules of engagement that she was always the final say in, in any area of, of, like, finance.

Um, I could influence-

William Salvi: Really defining the roles to not step on each other.

Kevin Hartz: Precisely.

William Salvi: My brother, my brother Chris and I, not to draw it back to me, but that was very important for us to, like, figure out what the roles were- Mm-hmm ... how, what, uh- You

Kevin Hartz: do it too?

William Salvi: You need the clarity. Yeah, otherwise- Yeah ... it's hard when you're so close with someone.

Mm-hmm. It's hard to, uh, it's hard to sometimes not butt heads if you're either working on the same thing and you think one is right or one is wrong, and so it's really important to get clear [00:33:00] goals

Kevin Hartz: as early as you can. And then that's a, um, but that's, you know, not doing that is one of these, like, major causes of startup death is when founders start, when they haven't defined that and they start getting on top- They step on, yeah

of each other and- It's a red flag ... and, you know, it melts down and a company kind of dissolves.

William Salvi: How did people, like, I don't mean to, I don't mean this question to pry in any way, but were, were there any experiences where it was just really difficult, like between the two of you? Like, truly husband and wife, like, man, that's,

Kevin Hartz: this is- Well, I mean, there were difficult experiences like- Yeah

um, like COVID. You know, we're, uh, uh, Eventbrite is a, a live, um, experiences company, and COVID came, uh, and we were, I don't know, at like a \$5 billion GMV run rate, um, you know, at, at one instance and- You know, that went down to- It just shattered it ... to negative. Yeah. Uh, I mean, it, like, you know, we [00:34:00] were just one of the most hits in, you know, in a world where there were a lot of companies doing quite well.

Like, DoorDash took off, um, and, and others, um, th- they were almost like the opposite. E-commerce and, and things did quite well. But, um, so we saw this and we hunkered down at our, in our home office. We had screens everywhere to, you know, keep track of what was happening all, all around. And, you know, we had to really kind of try to help our creators through this, this moment because they're all effectively SMBs, small businesses, that were, uh, hosting live experiences, and now they could host nothing.

Julia Hartz: It was sort of like having a child in the ICU during that period, and it was about a three-month really intense period of time, and they had- You were the

William Salvi: CEO at this time.

Julia Hartz: I was the CEO.

William Salvi: And it was a publicly traded company at this time. Correct.

Julia Hartz: Since 2018? Since 2018. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah. And, you know, I think, um, like, we had some knock-down, drag-out [00:35:00] fights then, which is not emblematic of our relationship, but I think that intensity really did, you know, it was appropriate for the time- It came out.

Yeah ... because if we didn't move, and move fast, and move decisively, so s- there's some really hard decisions, Eventbrite wouldn't exist. I mean, for all

intents and purposes, everything that we, that we existed for stopped happening. It was not, like, it was very dramatic. We had built the company over 14 years, had gotten to about 5 billion in, in gross, um, ticket value and, uh, in 14 days we were doing negative revenue, like sizable amounts.

Because if you imagine practically the events that were on the platform were no longer happening, and so people were asking for refunds, but our creators had already paid- Sure ... the operational costs for the events. It was terrible. And so, you know, I think that we, I, I came home from shutting the office down, you know, when everybody went to go work from home, and Kevin, [00:36:00] like, surprised me and, by setting up this war room in our, in our home office.

It was so romantic, you know? Like, oh my God, 'cause there were two chairs. So he was- That's right ... you know, the chairman, but, like, had a day job, and he dropped everything and we were just sort of, eh, you know, in our own very intense moment, not unlike when you have a sick kid and you've gotta get to the bottom of what's happening, and you need to, like, put your heads together.

But it was intense, for sure. Yeah.

Kevin Hartz: Hm.

William Salvi: And you went through the financial crisis, too, with Eventbrite.

Julia Hartz: We did. That was less intense, I feel like.

Kevin Hartz: Well, uh, yeah. I mean, the financial crisis in 2008, um, it was funny. We, um, I mean, the more interesting story was really w- we were at, um, Clarion Capital, and that's Peter's, um, hedge fund vehicle, uh, at their annual meeting and it was, like, the height of the market.

Um, this was in like late summer approaching fall of 2008, and it was on top of the, m- the Met, uh, [00:37:00] and you know, like museum. It was very fancy. And then on that Sunday we had brunch with some friends, um, Jane Lauder and Kevin Warsh.

Julia Hartz: Oh, I'm gonna stop. We can't do that story.

Kevin Hartz: Why not?

Julia Hartz: Because he's the head of the Federal Reserve.

He is now. Sorry. We're gonna- He is now. Oh, my God. We're gonna cut that out. Yeah, yeah, yeah.

William Salvi: Sorry. Wait, wait. Julia, wait, wait, wait, wait, wait. Let him keep going. No. Yeah.

Julia Hartz: No. No, no, no, no, no. Sorry.

William Salvi: Oh,

Julia Hartz: yeah. All right. We can't, we can't. Yeah, I can't do that.

William Salvi: No, it's all good. Yeah. Um- Yeah, yeah, yeah ... damn it, it was about to

be- While we're stopped,

William Salvi: oh, sorry. While we're stopped now- ... could you, uh, Kevin, pull that microphone down just a tiny little bit. It just keeps riding up on me. I know. It's trying to go- Also, I'm just gonna go, uh, I'm gonna go ahead and beg you to turn on the fan at, at speed one. I-

Kevin Hartz: is that possible?

William Salvi: I'll try and do a noise removal on it We can do a, a noise removal too on our end Do

Julia Hartz: you want me to make it... Do, are you putting

William Salvi: your- I can turn mine on. Yeah, yeah, I was gonna turn- Not good I'm sorry.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah, ours- I'm like ... even one, even one is loud Sorry to rat you out [00:38:00]

William Salvi: Don't worry.

Kevin Hartz: It was a good story. I kinda

William Salvi: wanna, I wanna hear that story afterwards.

Yeah. Oh, I'm sorry. No, don't be sorry. I understand. Hand,

Julia Hartz: hand holding.

William Salvi: Yeah, yeah, yeah. Um, I wanna know, uh, did anyone, did you have any difficulty as husband and wife, like as a unit w- either with investors or with people that you were pitching or partnerships? Did anyone, like, take it less seriously or, but did that ever become a thing?

Kevin Hartz: You mean as a couple? Like-

William Salvi: Yeah ...

Kevin Hartz: the, you know, uh, like there were investors that would just tell you flat out, like, "I'm not in- investing- I'm not getting involved in this ... in a husband and wife team." Yeah. "You two are just gonna bicker,"

Julia Hartz: you know? I mean, you had such a great way of, of, this is so Kevin. Uh, we would go into fundraising, when we finally did raise our first institutional round after we had bootstrapped and raised, you know, friends and family, you were like You would go into a meeting and you'd start with that.

Like, we would open the meeting with, "We'd like to talk about how we work together." And I mean, now I feel like there are [00:39:00] many great examples of couples who have co-founded successful businesses and stayed together. But then you had this sort of like trail of tears, you know, these horrific stories. And so what I thought was so brilliant about Kevin, and again, it's so emblematic of his personality, is he just went right at it.

And we gave a very straightforward answer, and then we'd move on. And it wasn't... It never really became an issue.

Kevin Hartz: Well, I had this mentor, I have this mentor, Pierre Lamond, and he was a chip guy. He created National Semiconductor in like the '60s, and then he was the first head of engineering at Cisco. Then he, he partnered with Don Valentine, um, at Sequoia.

Um, and he would, he would like talk to me about Pareto optimization. It's like kind of figuring out what your biggest problems were. Um, you know, in, and in the chip design area, it's like you run all these tests. Is, is there, you know, is there [00:40:00] a misalignment of the wafers? Is there too much, um, you know, a certain impurity in the, the, the wafers?

And you figure out which is causing the biggest problem, and you force rank them and then go after the, uh, the biggest, and then, um, kind of test again. And, and that process like eventually delivers you to nirvana. Just a very good way to do that. And going into those board meetings would be... Like, I loved like putting like the biggest problems of the company and the things that w-people were saying or happening in, in front of the board and, and have them kind of help me, uh, work through them.

Julia Hartz: Yeah. I feel like radical transparency has been, uh, without the fancy titling, has been a real core principle of Kevin's, and I learned that from him. I mean, you know, it's, uh, it's an interesting thing to have someone that you love so much that you're part of all their parts of [00:41:00] their lives, but also be your mentor.

And so, you know, I was able to... I'm not saying Kevin's old, but there is an age difference. And I was really a sponge learning a lot, and I feel like we handled our stuff. Like, we never made the fact that we were married someone else's problem.

Kevin Hartz: Is there anything that I was radically transparent about that you wish I wasn't?

Julia Hartz: All the time.

William Salvi: I was about to ask, like, how do you have a really difficult conversation where you almost don't want to... You wanna keep it like strictly about work versus you don't wanna go into anything that would ruffle any feathers with respect to the romantic relationship?

Kevin Hartz: Well, I was referring more to like, you know, like pimples and certain location of those.

Julia Hartz: No, I mean- She's getting

William Salvi: your camera ready, you know?

Julia Hartz: Yeah. I think when you, um, when you work with someone like Kevin, uh you or you live with [00:42:00] him, you start to embrace that level of transparency. And so for our family, there are no secrets.

William Salvi: There you go. It's just part of the-

Julia Hartz: It's just you're just all- Yeah

out there. And it's kind of, I mean, to say that I've become a better person is an understatement, just because I have learned to, to try to care less about what people think, but also to just be honest and open. And it's really refreshing, and I think that's one of the principles of what makes Eventbrite such a great culture is that, um, that level of transparency, that understanding that you are gonna know the truth.

And if you, if the truth isn't already out there, then Kevin Hartz is gonna walk down the hall and, like, uh- Say it ... you know, say it. And it's like, and it, it's not in a vicious way, not in a mean way, in a really just open, matter-of-fact way.

William Salvi: What's the, uh... I, I wanna know about taking companies public. So Zoom went public- Mm-hmm

and then Eventbrite went public.

Kevin Hartz: Yes. Zoom went public on the NASDAQ.

William Salvi: Okay.

Kevin Hartz: Um, and-

William Salvi: Were you the CEO at the time, or were you-

Kevin Hartz: I was not. Okay. John Coonz was the CEO. Okay. I [00:43:00] was on the board. Um,

William Salvi: and- Why does one... Talk to, to my audience, why does one decide, or a company, why does a company decide to go public?

Kevin Hartz: A company decides to go public, uh, to give liquidity to the shareholders.

Like, that's the traditional reason. Um, there are, there are many other reasons. I, I mean, even part of that is, like, you can access different forms of financing, larger forms of financing, um, through the, the public markets. Um, and I, I always saw it as, like, a, you know, as, like, competing in the sunlight. Like, there are so many, uh, companies in tech that have all these bad habits that they

kind of do in the secrecy of being a kind of covered-up private company that you never see.

Um, you know how they say sunlight is the best antiseptic? Like, out in the public arena, um, it really forces you to, you know, show, show your best. [00:44:00] Um, your team is competing, like, in the out and open. Um, and, you know, that's, that's a great feeling, and that's a great thing to do. And you've seen that the biggest companies in the world have, um, you know, progressed their way.

Whether it's NVIDIA, uh, its long road in the public markets, or, um, Amazon or, or others, uh, the public markets were key to it. Also, of course, you know, larger acquisitions and the like. Um, you know, Google would not have been able to acquire, uh, YouTube, for example.

William Salvi: What's the worst thing about having a public company, being in leadership at a public company?

Specifically usually with being the CEO of a publicly traded company, like, what's a, what's a, what's something that really grinded your gears when you were-

Julia Hartz: Well, I'll, I'll- ... leading Eventbrite? I'll just honestly say the first things that came to mind First one is the overhead cost of being a public company.

When you're at a [00:45:00] certain revenue threshold and valuation, it just starts to become egregious. I mean, there's just generally speaking, you know, tens of millions of dollars that goes into the procedural regulatory compliance. And frankly, I find it very predatory for, um, you know, all of these outside vendors to be, uh, preying upon a public company because you have to pay for these different services, and you have to, you literally have to do certain things to be a public company.

That costs a lot of money.

William Salvi: Can you explain some of them? Just because I'm, one, unaware of them-

Julia Hartz: Auditing ... and

William Salvi: two, I think it

Julia Hartz: would be- I mean, just like- Yeah ... you know, just the egregious audit bills because you could get sued if something were, were incorrect. Being a public company, it's a lot more, uh, expensive to get your, you know- 'Cause

William Salvi: everything

Julia Hartz: must be-

SOC compliance done ... yeah, right. Yeah. Um, and then- Well,

Kevin Hartz: we, we, we were like 24, 25 million a year in the, like hard costs.

Julia Hartz: Yeah. But then there's even- And then, yeah. Yeah. Yeah. So that's like, and- And

William Salvi: the hard costs of, from these vendors that would m-

Julia Hartz: Right ...

William Salvi: that you have to use for- Yeah ... being a public

Julia Hartz: company.

[00:46:00] Yeah, so that's silly. I mean, if we want more companies to be public companies and give the public a chance to invest in these public equities, public equities, I think that there's probably some disruption that should happen.

Other: Mm-hmm.

Julia Hartz: Um, the second thing is the soft c- uh, uh, cost in the form of, um, public company psychosis, which is, like everyone thinking you have to do a certain thing because you're public, and that just seeps into a culture, and it's really hard to mitigate.

You know, to, to try to get people to really focus on the customer and what's right versus what the public market is going to think. It takes a, a certain amount of, um, counterforce. And so that was a lot of lost productivity.

William Salvi: Can you provide an example of that? Is that like, just maybe say as a simple example, like worrying where the stock price might go based off a decision-

Julia Hartz: Yeah

William Salvi: in the short term, but really in your head- Yeah ... you're like, "But long term, this is the right decision."

Julia Hartz: Right. And

William Salvi: I, and we- So why are we worrying about the first two months of this decision?

Julia Hartz: I pledge to never bitch about being a public [00:47:00] company, so this is not me complaining. Because it's a choice, and we had the, um, shareholder, you know, vote to, to decide whether or not to be a public company.

But I just think the reality of it is it's a broken system, and it's not benefiting the public e- public equity owner. And if it's not managed thoughtfully, it can kind of become the headline of the company, and I just don't think that's right. I do think you need to respect your shareholders. You need to respect what you've signed up for.

But I don't think you as a CEO should allow it to become the thing. And I think so often, more often than not, it just, it kind of grinds you down and gets you into this mindset of like, "Oh, no, but it's all about your public market," you know, quarterly calls, and actually it's about the business. The final and third thing I'll say is that- Look, listen, we were a small cap public company and I, so I got a lot of advice.

And I would, I [00:48:00] would try to do advice through, like, investor relations. What I would try to do is seek the through line, and I actually do listen, and I'm a sponge, and I like to find the patterns, and I like to apply the learnings. So I loved the quarterly calls. But eventually it got to a place where it was such a, um-

William Salvi: Very frequent

Julia Hartz: Well, it's also, like, the advice you're getting is, like, akin to a toddler who d- who you're asking, like, "What do you want to eat for dinner?" Like, it's just like a, it's just like a wild swinging pendulum that you realize, oh, if I were to take the advice every single call As it's given, the company would look like a madhouse.

It would just, the strategy would- Be ridiculous ... be up and down and all around. Yeah. So I think that it also is, it's a signal. You should listen, you should glean wisdom, but you have to do it really carefully and really know where you're going. Like, and not be swayed by the current temperature.

[00:49:00]

William Salvi: How often do you guys check the stock price?

Julia Hartz: Uh- Oh, I mean, all the time, but like, that's just- Is it- ... 'cause it's on your phone ... does it get addict- And it's like-

William Salvi: Does it get addicting to check it?

Julia Hartz: No. No, it was never really a great, exciting story. So I, I like, it was, uh, I-

William Salvi: Well, I'm sure during COVID it was actually really stressful.

Julia Hartz: It was really nice to turn that off when we sold the company.

William Salvi: I'm sure. Um-

Kevin Hartz: One, one other benefit of the public company, it reminds me of like, um, y- you know, when Julia was talking about the feedback from investors, like yeah, there's people all around the world, like, kind of looking at your stock and like writing things about it and reaching out to you. And so it's a chance to get all these other interesting perspectives.

Um, I, I think I recall, um, Bill Gates finding a report by a young Bill Gurley, uh, and called him into his office or called him up to Seattle to, to meet. And, you know, because Bill had some interesting insights. And so that's a benefit to it. But the reality is that, that in the, you know, [00:50:00] small cap market, this like billion-dollar range, in a world where we have, you know, the magnificent, is it nine now or...

Uh, and, you know, we have these trillion-dollar companies, uh, the, the funds have all gotten bigger. It's very hard, uh, it's harder to, for investors to support those. Fidel- Fidelity, for example, is like a kind of staple investor, and I'm not sure they would even invest in, you know, companies under a couple billion dollars.

William Salvi: Is that good for the public markets?

Kevin Hartz: No, I, because you, you d- you need to keep kind of planting, um, you need to keep watering flowers to bloom, you know? Right. And, and so many companies start from that, um, billion-dollar level and, and grow.

William Salvi: Well, well, I wanna get into that a little bit more, but I wanna, I wanna talk about the selling of these companies.

These are large deals. Can you just walk me through both with Zoom and Eventbrite, like how that works? So Zoom sold in 2015 to PayPal for 1.1-ish billion. Mm-hmm, that's correct. All cash. And [00:51:00] then Eventbrite in April of this year, 2026, April? Mm-hmm. Uh, for 500 million. Mm-hmm. So how does that... It's, talk to me about like the conversations prior to this beginning.

Like, talk to me about selling a company for that amount. How does that process work? I mean, tell me about it. You guys are at the leadership level of both of these companies. You're the CEO of Eventbrite. You were, uh, you were at the leadership level at Zoom. So-

Kevin Hartz: Mm-hmm ...

William Salvi: tell me about it.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah. M- maybe I'll start because Zoom- Yeah

was like the predecessor. Yeah, in the case of Zoom, you know, it felt like- Things were going well, like the company was profitable and, um, you know, what, 400 or so million in, in net revenue. Um, and, you know, there was just, like, a discussion around finding an exit and, um, you know, maybe the, the team was a bit, like, tired, um, you know, after, you know, the company was, at that point, [00:52:00] um, 14 years old.

And, you know, we, we used a investment bank. Um, we... Who did we use? Catalyst, um, Frank Quattrone's firm. Um, and, you know, went around and, and met with, with different potential buyers. That was mainly the CEO John Kunze's job, although I went to one. Uh, to- I went and we met with Meta and, um, Zuck, but I just couldn't figure out how this could fit, you know?

Um-

William Salvi: Were they interested?

Kevin Hartz: They, they were, and I, you know, I, um... Y- you know, they want- th- they, at that time, wanted to build, uh, or turned out wanted to build a kind of global payments network. Um-

William Salvi: I assume Facebook Marketplace at that time was starting.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah, I think it was- Yeah, sh- it had to have been around that time

maybe, yeah, just getting off the ground. Yeah. So [00:53:00] that, that might have been the component to it. Um- And, you know, PayPal was the buyer. PayPal saw the comps in the market of Western Union and, and others that are big businesses. Um, you know, and the transaction happened very quickly. Um, you know, like in hindsight, um, at that, y- you know, in 2015 there's a tiny little startup called Remitly and a tiny little startup called TransferWise, now Wise.

Um, they're both, uh, public now and, you know, very large market caps, I think on the order of 10 billion or so, but relatively large. And, you know, I think we underestimated how big the market would, would grow. And, you know, frankly it, i- if it had stayed independent, I, I mean, who knows what would've happened, but, um, maybe that's that argument for staying [00:54:00] independent indefinitely because the, the market was really just starting.

Mm-hmm. Um, and just has kept growing and growing and growing. The market is, you know, globalization. Um, and people move overseas for a better life and jobs, and as an adjunct to that, they send money back to their families. Um, and, you know, we, when we... I th- I think when we sold the business, we were doing about 6 billion in, in transaction volume at \$200 per transaction.

Um, and, you know, it's certainly grown inside of, of PayPal. Um, and, and so it's been a, a great asset for them. They also clamped down on the, the CAC and marketing spend to, you know, harvest more, to gain more earnings. Um, and, you know, that gave like a, a nice additional benefit to Remitly and [00:55:00] TransferWise and

William Salvi: others.

How long did the process take to cut the, the, from conversation one to sale?

Kevin Hartz: M- a matter of weeks.

William Salvi: Oh, wow.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah.

William Salvi: So quick. Yeah. I would assume quick for a size of \$1.1 billion. Mm. Maybe I'm wrong. I don't know.

Kevin Hartz: You, I, I mean, like there, you know, the folks in the space are all pros. Um, and, you know, certainly PayPal, like we'd known them, you know, from the beginning.

You had a

William Salvi: relationship. Yeah. We

Kevin Hartz: had a relationship there. It was like, it was relatively easy.

William Salvi: Yeah. How about you, Julia? I'm interested in selling now, uh, Eventbrite and how it's been since April.

Julia Hartz: You know, I think that it was, um

A decision that had a lot of confluence of factors, and I think that I was the last person to get to the point of, you know, thinking that selling the company would, taking it private would be a good idea. I'm incredibly stubborn when I [00:56:00] love something a lot, and, you know, I really believe in the mission of the company, and I think that's emblematic in what we've built.

But it was about right around our 20th Eventbrite-versary, and looking ahead, I mean, it's un- undeniable to see the amount of change that's happening in an unprecedented, you know, velocity. Uh, and really coming through COVID was something that I think needed that founder-led leadership and energy. But coming out to the next era takes a totally new perspective.

And so it really was about understanding where Eventbrite could land to get that next burst of energy and innovation through transformation, right? So through making a lot of changes. Um, but it was really hard for, for me to get to the point of, of saying, "Okay, let's, let's go do this." Let's pursue

Kevin Hartz: [00:57:00] this,

Julia Hartz: yeah.

Yeah, yeah. So I was so- I always felt like I was like a granny with a shotgun on the porch of Eventbrite- ... saying like, "Don't even come c- near here." Um, and so to that end, I think, you know, I, I definitely have learned a lot in that. And I would say like I'm, you know, uh, undeniably loyal. Um, but once we made the rational case and the decision to go in that direction, I was...

I had to lead from the front, and I was really sure of what we were going to do and how we were going to do it. It didn't come without trade-offs, but I'm really proud of the direction we moved in. We sold the company to Bending Spoons, and they just recently went public actually. So Eventbrite was private for, like, a second.

Yeah, they were private for a month and then- Um, had like, took a knee and then went back in. Uh, you know, I found them to be incredibly thoughtful, uh, very direct, very transparent, very sure of where they wanted to go. Um, they had been interested in Eventbrite for, [00:58:00] for, you know, a lot longer than the active conversation of actually consummating that, that, uh, transaction.

But I, I felt like you could always tell, like, with anything like hiring someone or doing a deal, you know, there's always the lead up and everybody's on their best behavior. And then it's between the time that the offer's made and the offer closes, whether it's a person or a company or a transaction or a partnership, where, like, you really get to know one another.

Other: Mm-hmm.

Julia Hartz: And, um, and so I had always had this philosophy in recruiting that that's when you really understand what a person's, like, core attributes and values are. And so when we went through this process, it took about three months from, from, um, letter of intent to close. I was pleasantly surprised about how many decisions, how many jump balls that, that they had to call where they went the way of the, of we call them Britelings, but of our, of our people.

And that made me feel really good about the decision even more so beyond the strategy and the [00:59:00] execution of what they're going to do with Eventbrite. So I think we hope that Eventbrite outlives us, you know? And that I feel like this gives it that option to do, or that, that, that great opportunity and runway to do that.

But to, you know, walk away cleanly from something that you kind of were a part of birthing is, it's definitely, uh, it's a thing.

William Salvi: Yeah.

Julia Hartz: It's, yeah.

William Salvi: I'm sure it is. I'm sure it's hard. Yeah. I, so I mentioned headlines earlier, like the headline of sale for, uh, Zoom sells to PayPal for 1.1 billion and, and Eventbrite-

Kevin Hartz: Actually Z- um, PayPal stipulated that it would, that the press release would say 890 million.

They subtracted the cash, which is totally, um, non-standard, but they wanted to make sure it looked like it was under a billion. But when you added it all- How

William Salvi: come?

Kevin Hartz: Because it, because it makes it look like they got a really good deal- A better deal. Yeah ... and that [01:00:00] they didn't overpay for something at a billion.

It's interesting. It's a- Yeah ... good strategy.

William Salvi: Nice little strategy there.

Kevin Hartz: I, I remember, like, talking to David Sacks about it, like when, and he's like, "You gotta change that right now." Like, "Make them change it. Make them change it." And I'm like

William Salvi: What would be the downside of it going too high for them? Like who, who cares if people think it's a-

Kevin Hartz: Well, it's just, you know, it's, it's just one of these things they wanna, like, maintain.

William Salvi: Yeah.

Kevin Hartz: I guess some comps investor relations person wanted to just show how many- The comps teams Like they- The

William Salvi: internal comps teams-

Kevin Hartz: Yeah ...

William Salvi: always get in the way, don't they?

Kevin Hartz: Well, I mean, in the- Not you specifically ... in the big scheme of things, you know, they, they bought Braintree, uh- Okay ... for, um, you know, which is now their, like, com- stripe competitor, um, and included Venmo in it.

Um, they bought us, Zoom. Um, so in, in the end, they were, like, great assets that, that they got ahold of, but they were just positioning them as modest as possible.

William Salvi: B- but a- a- after the sale [01:01:00] I think ev- any, uh, someone who's reading about this story, both of them, Eventbrite, Zoom, and reading about you guys, I think anyone would say, like, "Wow, incredible.

Incredible exit. Amazing." Good job to you two. Ca- uh, caps off for you guys. What would you say would be a downside? Or I don't need you to start talking crap about the, the deal or anything, but more so what would be a downside of something like the deals that you made? I mean, quite literally, what's, what's a, a, a situation within Zoom, and what's the situation within Eventbrite where you're like, "You know what?

I'm, I'm not happy about that"?

Kevin Hartz: Well, I mean, you know, within Zoom, like, in 2020 hindsight, i- if we'd stayed independently independent, you know, it looks like we would've been... We would've had a-

William Salvi: \$10 billion ...

Kevin Hartz: \$10 billion or \$20 billion company. I mean, we've, um... You know, that's where you build and grow. Um, you know, clearly the remittance market [01:02:00] has grown and grown and grown.

You look at all the payments companies, um, you know, I think I saw Stripe is at 1.7 trillion in volume. We'd never... Yeah. An annualized volume. We never imagined that. And would we have expanded into tangential markets to be much bigger? Um, perhaps.

William Salvi: Do you ever think about that?

Kevin Hartz: I try not to, because I have enough things that keep me awake at night.

William Salvi: You know, like, if you have a good win, sometimes it's just good to think about the good win.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah. That's- For a second ... you know, you gotta have an optimism.

William Salvi: I wish I coulda- Yep ... a better win. Yeah.

Kevin Hartz: So thanks for digging that up. Yeah. I'm gonna go and cry- Yeah ... after this.

William Salvi: No, don't cry. And then Julia, I wanna know, like, it's, it's more recent, I guess, so you don't have the same- Yeah

hindsight right now, or you both don't have the same hindsight with Eventbrite. But what, what's something about the Eventbrite sale where you're... maybe you're not thrilled with?

Julia Hartz: Well, I think that we built a, a love brand, and I think the reason why [01:03:00] Eventbrite is a love brand is because we built an incredible community and culture.

And the reason why we built a c- an incredible community and culture is because we were enabling the most amazing people in the world. I mean, the people who bring others together through life experiences are this, like, incredibly rich, intelligent, thoughtful, dynamic, creative, intellectual group of humans.

And so that's the thing that feels The saddest to me is that I don't have that connection every single day at, at my fingertips. Really, the passion that I have for what we support and, um, you know. So that, that's the hardest part- Yeah ... I think

Kevin Hartz: is, is- I, I think Will's trying to make us cry. This is just- I know, yeah

one of these, like, epis- like, Oprah episodes where you-

William Salvi: You know, my brother Chris tries to- It's a lot more ... he tries to say I- he wants to make this show where it's Oprah Winfrey and Andrew Ross Sorkin, like, combined.

Kevin Hartz: Oh. Oh.

William Salvi: Yeah, 'cause I'm not Andrew Ross Sorkin, 'cause he's, like, [01:04:00] true CNBC- Yeah ... like, financial journalist.

Kevin Hartz: I have an Andrew Ross Sorkin story to tell you right after this.

William Salvi: I'm really excited about it. You're gonna love it. I wanna meet him, uh- Oh ... one day. I, I DM'd him on Instagram and he got back to me, but he won't meet me. Andrew, if you ever see this episode, please meet me. Um, but I wanna Sorry, I go on tangents sometimes.

It's a problem. I have ADHD. Um, after selling, why do you guys wanna keep working? I assume you're fine. It- I assume you're fine financially. Yeah. You could pursue... Why start another company? I, I know you're, you're starting, like, a home, uh- Home security business ... home security business.

Kevin Hartz: Soram.

William Salvi: Um, you're, you both are active investors.

Uh, obviously there's nothing wrong with that, but, and there's nothing wrong with starting- A, a, a

Kevin Hartz: star, uh-

William Salvi: But, like- ...

Kevin Hartz: investment fund ...

William Salvi: why, why not... I'm sorry, investment fund. Uh, why not-

Why not point your gun to help society do something else versus start another company or invest to, in, in other companies? Like, why not just, "You know what? I'm just gonna focus [01:05:00] on this one societal issue, and I'm just gonna..." I'm, I'm curiously- I- ... asking. I'm not, I'm not accusing you. But it, why not, why keep working on a new company?

I'm- Well- ... I'm wondering if I would.

Kevin Hartz: Like, the, um, the, the retired talk show host Jay Leno, um, once, like, told this story about, you know, he's, like, a type A person. He's, like, very engaged and working hard and driving hard, and he describes a story of going on vacation. Um, and, you know, like, gets up and goes and sits on, like, a lawn chair, uh, and gets his book out, and he's, like, reading and reading and, like, starting to get fidgety and looking around, and, like, seven minutes had, you know, transpired.

Like, he just couldn't, like, sit still. That's, like, how I feel all the, all the time. Like, I don't wanna go and sit on a be- I mean, I like sitting on beaches, but not for any- Day. Yeah, yeah ... great length of time. Yeah. [01:06:00] But, and there's just, this is such an exciting period. The, this is, like, the most exciting period in, that the tech world has ever had.

Like, all these waves before us, the '80s and with personal computing in the '90s, with the internet in the 2000s, with mobile, like, that's expanded the world, expanded people's connectivity, expanded all these markets. And now in the, the 2020s, uh, is this AI era, and it's having such a big impact. And, um, you know, I wanna be, uh, shaping that and involved in, in other things.

It's also just intellectual curiosity of learning. Um, you know, I, like, meet with these different companies. I met with a chip company yesterday and a, um, a drone business in, um, in El Segundo. And, [01:07:00] you know, it's, it's so exciting and interesting to learn about all these different businesses, and that's what now investing affords me.

But also, I get to pay it back and mentor, um, all these new founders.

Julia Hartz: I don't know that I'll do another company. I actually don't know what I'm going to do. Would

William Salvi: you ever wanna be a CEO again?

Julia Hartz: Well, I, I don't know, and I truly, that's like, it's the hardest answer to give you because I'm ... I d- I never don't know.

Um, but I truly don't know. And I think i- i- it, it's not because I'm confused, it's because I don't think I should know right now. I think working on something that is such a core part of who you are and, and, you know, takes up a- all of

your everything is such an honor, and it's such a privilege. And, you know, Eventbrite means a lot to the world, you know?

And so-

William Salvi: I use it, by the way.

Julia Hartz: Thank you.

William Salvi: We have an event next week.

Julia Hartz: That [01:08:00] never gets old.

William Salvi: I'm not kidding. Thank you. Yeah. We have an event next week, and I have an Eventbrite link.

Julia Hartz: Yay.

William Salvi: I'm really

Julia Hartz: pumped. We are, we're, we're so-

Kevin Hartz: You can still call Julia for customer service. Oh, yeah. I will. I will.

Julia Hartz: Good.

Kevin Hartz: Yeah. Her phone number is- I didn't mean to cut- 415- I didn't mean to cut

William Salvi: you off, yeah.

Julia Hartz: So, um, but I have a little bit of a different perspective from Kevin. Like, my core truth is that I think that was lightning in a bottle, and I don't expect that it'll happen again. And I don't think that that means that I won't try. Certainly if I try to build another company again, it will be with Kevin.

I mean, that for sure is a, an experience that I would do over and over and over again. That's tight. Um, but I don't know. I just don't know. And I think it's really important for me to sit in the unknown and be marveling. Like, in three

months I've had so many eye-opening experiences that I hadn't had during this really critical time of building my life, my family, the company.

Um, and I, and I wouldn't say, I'm not [01:09:00] sad. I'm really, really, I'm choosing to be really happy that it happened, and the fact that we did create something that means something to culture- And I feel really good about where it is now, but I just don't know that I'll, that I'll do it again. Yeah. So we'll see. I, right now I'm having a lot of fun learning, just being a complete sponge.

So I'm, I'm doing all the things that, you know, a lot of people are doing, but I'm like an AI hobbyist learning about different things, and I'm marveling in the luxury of time to help other people. That feels really good because I'd become a ninja at time management, which meant that I didn't really have a lot of time to do much else than survive, be an o- like be an okay mom, an okay wife, and, you know, okay leader, all the okays.

And now I feel like I can really dig in, you know-

William Salvi: Focus on some other things, like more- Yeah ... intentionality.

Julia Hartz: Maybe

William Salvi: I, I can be

Julia Hartz: excellent at something. We'll see.

William Salvi: Um- It's been 60 minutes. Awesome. Thank you. Let's go into some macro topics. Mm-hmm. You guys just [01:10:00] mentioned AI. Kevin, you just mentioned we're in a very exciting time from a technological s-perspective.

I am interested, uh, if you asked anyone probably in the 1990s, early 2000s, if the internet would be good for the world, just like a very broad question, but would the internet be good for the world? Or even if social media, uh, in the late 2000, right around there is when like Twitter and Facebook started to really catch on.

But late 2000s, social media came about, and would you ask those leaders would, will social media be a net positive for the world? Um, we, we thought like the internet would probably provide, it would expand our minds and provide a lot of openness, look at all this information, and social media, it's all this great connectivity.

And, and in many ways it is every single day, it's doing exactly that. But also, like it went in a lot of different directions that made our [01:11:00] society worse. So I'm wondering, in your perspective, will AI be net positive or net negative for society?

Kevin Hartz: Yeah. Well, I mean, the internet, like was, there was so much positivity and that's remained relatively strong, you know, with a few hiccups.

Social media turned out to be like cigarettes, where, um, you know, it seemed really great and then you find out that it kills you later. Um, you know, and so that's been, you know, a, a fairly big disappointment, and it's also put, you know, the public, um, on alert, you know, for what's coming next. AI at its, you know, from- like the world's perspective seems, you know, is, is always portrayed as, you know, destroying the planet and, you know, the, uh, like takeover Terminator-like films, [01:12:00] uh, as this like v- very negative thing.

And you have this like doubly, uh, bad thing, uh, and that is, uh, it taking away jobs. Uh, and that's in, in the kind of- f- uh, like this, uh, I don't know, like we've fanned our own flames by talking about AI safety at ad nauseam and how dangerous these products could be, you know, so we've, like, scared our own audience.

Um, I don't, I, uh, just like any other tool all the way back to fire, uh, it's an in- it, it, it is and it's going to be an incredibly valuable tool. And, you know, it, it will actually create more jobs, um, in the sense that, you know, with prosperity, um, that it brings an automation and so on that you have a, a n- a net [01:13:00] positive creation just as if you look at today at the size of even the tech industry, um, or other industries that have aided from automation and, and the like, um, i- and compare that to 50 years ago or 100 years ago or 200 years ago, um, you know, we've made great progress.

So I see it all as a positive. Um, we just have a very tough situation. It's also exacerbated by, I'm gonna have to throw out the, the wealth divide, um, which has become r- very, um, acute, acutely clear in the, you know, last 10 years of, um, you know, this, this concentration of wealth.

William Salvi: It seems like the AI, at least right now, it's exacerbating that though.

Kevin Hartz: Yes.

William Salvi: Right now it is.

Kevin Hartz: Yes.

William Salvi: Um, and I'm, I'm wondering, like, I'm not, I'm not necessarily just generally for [01:14:00] government stepping in and s- slowing industries down. Mm-hmm. But at what point do we take past examples like the internet or like social media and say we need to intervene before it becomes the Jurassic Park line where it's like you didn't think about what you were creating- Yeah

and you were s- you were so excited to create it, but you didn't, you forgot to ask, like, why you're creating it.

Kevin Hartz: My, my advisor in college at Stanford was this fellow Irvin Remsen, and he was famous for Remsen's rule, and that is everything the government touches turns to shit. Um, and, like, uh, like h- it, it's a nightmare to think about the government trying to regulate, um, AI, and we have to do it in an intelligent manner if it's even done, but more so than what happens, do we...

Th- the, the Chinese are moving incredibly fast. Do we just allow them to, to gain that kind of supremacy? So it's, it's not a simple question, um, [01:15:00] to answer. The other side is that, you know, like, you know, nuclear weapons or nuclear ability, um, you know, sure, like, it, you try to regulate in the US, but there's always bad actors or others overseas that, that can do it beyond the Chinese

Julia Hartz: Oh, um-

William Salvi: I'm staring at you now for

Julia Hartz: the- I have so many things and I, I ... So, uh, so many things running through my head. I think, um, first and foremost, you know, th- we definitely learn the hard way that when you close the, the barn doors a- after the horses get out, any sort of regulation is really gonna be null and void, and that's, you know, all around social media.

And I think we did think... I tend to be an optimist on most things, and I tend to take a long view. So I think, you know, in the end I, I look at the good that social media has brought, which is connecting a world that was disconnected, creating advocacy and visibility and enablement [01:16:00] to people who didn't have that voice.

Um, and it also has an incredibly dark underbelly. I tend to think that the, that if you, if you follow the line, it always comes back to humans. So, you know, then

I skip forward to the AI wealth divide, and that's not because AI, it's because humans decide to value companies at, at a certain mark, and are wildly, you know, it's, uh, egregious in that.

And so, you know, capitalism or, and, and especially like venture capitalism is just, I think, completely off its rocker. Oh, yeah You no longer ha- you no longer have startups starting actually in a way that a startup should be starting. You have startups racing to get the most amount of capital and put that to work as quickly as possible.

I just think that that creates a certain incentive system and a certain outcome that isn't exactly aligned with the great innovations of the past. Um, I do think that we need to regulate ourse- [01:17:00] we need to be thoughtful and regulate ourselves as a human society. Um, some days it feels like we are all racing as fast as we can to get that next check, to get that next round closed, to get that next, um, tool in the hands of people that is literally going to make us extinct.

And so I, I, I, while I am an optimist, I'm also like, wow, it's all in our hands. There's a reality. Yeah. So collectively, we need to decide that we want our children to grow up in a healthy world. We want there to be access to safe and powerful learning tools. We want, you know, education to be democratized.

But I also think it's way, way, way too early to call the ball, and I actually would say it's too early to call the ball on social media, too. I mean, of course this was going to happen When you look at it in hindsight, but I don't know that we have enough time- Maybe ... I don't know that we have enough time to- 'Cause

like call the outcome on, on the net positives and the net negatives, and believe you me, we have- Definitely have the bad outcome ... we have very personal- [01:18:00] Yeah ... very personal interactions with the negatives. So we, we actually qui- quite very viscerally know the negatives of social media, having two teenage daughters.

The, I think that we're a bit sh- short-sighted in two ways. One is we're trying to translate that quickly into AI, which I just don't think the two things are very similar at all. And two is that w- the final thing I'll say on, 'cause you gave me the soapbox, uh- ... is that, uh, I find it very strange that we're not talking about the impacts of a global pandemic anymore, that we're not...

I don't wanna like trauma-

William Salvi: 100% ...

Julia Hartz: stew- It messed us up ... but what the actual fuck? Like- Yeah, it

William Salvi: messed us up ... and

Julia Hartz: I hope we keep that. I mean-

William Salvi: I will

Julia Hartz: keep it in, yeah ... it messed-

William Salvi: This is our

Julia Hartz: show ... a lot of people up, and we're not, and we're not really, we're not really appreciating that right now, and I think in 20 years we will.

William Salvi: Yeah. I, I, I, I will say one parallel about social media companies with, and they're s- they're somewhat intertwined directly and s- [01:19:00] and they're intertwined indirectly as well. But like at the start of social media, 'cause I, I, I'm 35, I had a bit of a b- best of both worlds, so to speak, where I got social media at a time where I wasn't, it wasn't predatory.

Um, and when I say predatory, I don't, there weren't ads being thrown in my face at all times. There weren't a bajillion profiles and I don't know which ones are bots, which ones are real people. At the time when something went viral, it was because people were sharing it. It wasn't because it was orchestrated viral, or it was because it was bots or whatever.

So I guess my point is, is like businesses do what businesses are gonna do, and that's like they're, they are charged to grow, especially when they get, become public. You have investors, you have, you have, you have to grow. You have to innovate. And so the parallel there with AI is that- Mm-hmm ... I'm just wondering, and I don't disagree with Kevin either, it's not like I'm saying, "Well, the government just needs to step in and that'll fix it."

It's like, well, that's kind of a complicated question, too. But at the same time, I worry that the race to the top [01:20:00] will create a little bit more of that pred-predatory nature- Mm ... for the sake of growth versus for the sake of, "Hey, we're global conne- we're connecting everyone globally. We're social media.

This is fun." I get to, I, I, the reason I- Great point ... connected with you both was actually through social media. Yeah. I like social media generally. I'm, I'm old enough to not, uh, feel the negative effects and know what's be- bullshit and

what's not online. But, you know, I'm, I'm just interested where this might go with artificial intelligence companies, uh, that have a grip on, like, mass society, specifically, like, the two main ones right now.

'Cause there are a lot of AI- AI is used too broadly right now. Mm-hmm.

Julia Hartz: Right.

William Salvi: Because there's so much innovation going on in, in science and medicine that, like, don't, doesn't get talked about enough, and we're talking about, like, LLMs only. So-

Julia Hartz: Well, you always have to have a villain, right? So I mean, that's human nature, is that the way that we rationalize our opinions and stories, and the way that we kind of arm ourselves with righteousness is to [01:21:00] declare a villain.

And I think that in these cases, sometimes we've been really fast to declare the villain because then that allows us to say, "Well, it's just all their fault," when we're not really looking in the mirror at ourselves as a society. And, and to- Don't

Kevin Hartz: disagree- But Will has a great point on, you know, this race that, that pressure to, to grow, the desire to wanna be, to excel, and it had driven, you know, the algorithm to start doing things that were unintended, um, you know, in social media, and that's a very good analogy to apply to To the AI race.

And it's interesting because, you know, OpenAI and s- and especially Anthropic have emphasized from the beginning that they're trying to do this for the good of humanity and will not fall into that. But, um, you know, when you see them compete, they compete like they- Yeah ... they're playing to win- Mm ... and they, they will kill to not lose.

William Salvi: Sam Altman went from, [01:22:00] "I am a nonprofit CEO making 70K a year" to "I'm gonna be a trillion-dollar IPO real quick." Mm. Um, I, b- I'm not, do you know, we can all have our own opinions on Altman, but I, I, I'm interested, you guys have children. We do. What technology do you allow them or not allow them to utilize? So you have an 18-year-old daughter and a 16-year-old daughter?

Julia Hartz: We have 18, 14- 14,

William Salvi: okay ...

Julia Hartz: 23 months, and 18 months.

William Salvi: So the 14-year-old's probably, like, super susceptible to more, you know- Oh, yeah ... Instagram, TikTok, um, I'm sure the 18-year-old's getting out of that a little bit. Mm-hmm. But, like- But, yeah, the, I would say- What, what do you guys police, so to speak, on- Well,

Julia Hartz: yeah

children? I mean, the most brilliant technology that we've brought into the home that has really helped, um, you know, I, I would say, like, r- large communication and trust is this, um, this button that will record your voice, and Kevin has recorded, "I want a cookie," and our 18-month-old just sits and hits it- Oh my gosh

all day long, and it's Kevin's voice [01:23:00] saying, "I want a cookie." So we'll go from there. That's the best thing.

Kevin Hartz: Uh, you know, I mean-

Julia Hartz: Where would you take

Kevin Hartz: it? Uh, uh, well, look, I, I would just want-

Producer: Hey, hey, I'm so sorry. Uh, one of our cameras went down. Oh. Can you give us just 10 seconds to figure out- Yeah ... what went wrong?

Yep. So sorry about that.

William Salvi: No worries.

Julia Hartz: Perfect timing.

William Salvi: Which one was it? Mine, hopefully. 'Cause my camera's... Mine- Yeah, it was, it was yours. Oh, nice. My camera is the one that's least shown, so I'm actually glad it's mine. Oh, nice. Yeah, yeah. 'Cause we can always cut to that one- Side ... and do you guys. Yeah.

Kevin Hartz: How sweaty are you?

And just so you know, Will, we just hit

Julia Hartz: 75 minutes. You look fine.

William Salvi: I'm not too bad. Yeah. The problem

Julia Hartz: is-

William Salvi: I got a couple spots ... it's underneath. I don't know.

Julia Hartz: Yeah. I know, I know. This is bad. If you want Kevin to check it out afterwards, like give you a thumbs up- Yeah.

Kevin Hartz: I need to smell it to-

William Salvi: Yeah, yeah.

Julia Hartz: Oh my God.

William Salvi: I'm not too bad. I thought of this, honestly, was a... So when we first started- Mm-hmm ... I felt some drippies going down. Mm. I was like, "Oh, no." Really? We're 10 minutes in. It's because you- Aw. I'm sorry about this. But now you're okay.

Kevin Hartz: No, no, no worries. This is our first- I kind of like it. It means, like, we're working hard.

William Salvi: We are. What do you guys think so far?

Kevin Hartz: I love it. Love it. I [01:24:00] enjoyed it. I, I- I'm gonna- ... I don't want any tech with my daughters, but you know, like, that's not the reality is, uh, the 18-year-old is, like, moved on. She- She, or she, she's matured to a point, but damage already done from the past. Mm-hmm. The 14-year-old, we're, we're, like, fighting tooth and nail to get social media away from her.

And then-

William Salvi: Which is so interesting- Yeah ... because she's 14, and you don't want her to be, like, a dork with her friends that- Right ... doesn't have social media.

Kevin Hartz: You

William Salvi: can't communicate with them. And then, yeah, you can't communicate- Yeah ... with them in the normal sense. Yeah. And then also, but, you know.

Kevin Hartz: It's like, "Oh, I would've met you, but..."

Yeah, no, it's, it's, it's tough. I love those, uh... You know, you can do the, you could put on the... Is it, like, the, um... There's a mode on the iPhone that's like a, um- Sorry,

William Salvi: guys. It's all good. H-

Kevin Hartz: what's the term? I don't wanna say handicap mode. It's like a sh- Right ... it's like a, it's like a eye impair- it's like a seeing impaired mode that just puts, like, six [01:25:00] buttons and- I

William Salvi: know exactly what you're talking about.

Yeah. There's, like, the... It's, isn't that interesting? You cr- like, Tac To Battle Tac. You- Mm-hmm. Yeah ... you, like, you have the, and then the brick thing that, like-

Kevin Hartz: Yeah ...

William Salvi: doesn't allow you to-

Kevin Hartz: Yeah. So- For other reasons ... you just, you can use the phone. You can use, like, GPS and, but you can't use- What the hell? Uh, it's just the, the- Are we still recording, Sweetness?

Are you

William Salvi: gone? Okay,

Kevin Hartz: cool. It's just the, like, accessibility. It's, like, a certain accessibility mode.

William Salvi: Yeah. Um, but yeah, like, m- what- tech don't you allow them to use, your, your, your children? Unless you just want to move. I think we may have already-

Julia Hartz: Well, yeah ... I think we moved I, I, they, uh, we could go down. Our, our-

Kevin Hartz: The babies will get no tech.

Julia Hartz: The babies get zero

William Salvi: tech. Zero nothing.

Kevin Hartz: They're getting,

Julia Hartz: like- Except for the, "I want a cookie button" ... sticks

Kevin Hartz: and stones.

William Salvi: Yeah, that's good. I want a cookie. Mine is too.

Kevin Hartz: Except for the cookie button.

William Salvi: I can't get my daughter to stop. She, uh, we, we- yeah, it's hot in Chicago lately. Mm-hmm. And so she, she, we have, like, this, what is it?

Like, a water table. Yeah. Mm. It's great.

Julia Hartz: Yeah.

William Salvi: It's a great toy.

Julia Hartz: Yeah.

William Salvi: But, like, she just, like, tries to [01:26:00] drink the water all the time. I'm like, "Please stop." Oh. Yeah. "There's something in there." She's gonna- Please stop. She's on the race to

Julia Hartz: parasite.

William Salvi: She

Julia Hartz: really is. Yeah. Yeah. Yeah, and I'm- She's

William Salvi: gonna

Kevin Hartz: have explosive

William Salvi: diarrhea

I'm literally like, "Please stop." That's for me. Yeah. I need that diet- Yeah, you're like, "I want that" ... for the five-day diet. Yeah. Um, but d- what about the valuations of some of these companies, including SpaceX, uh, you know, the, the, the future valuations of Anthropic and OpenAI? Um, does it worry you at all from, like, a financial system perspective, the money that's going into artificial intelligence?

Are we throwing... Like, you, you, you both were around for the, for the dotcom. Like-

Kevin Hartz: Mm-hmm ...

William Salvi: are we throwing money at something, uh- Yeah ... too willingly?

Kevin Hartz: Well, I mean, I, I really wanna just try to understand where we are in the cycle. Like, you know, we're, we're in a society of capitalism, and the pendulum of capitalism is never still, you know, right in the middle.

It swings hard one way, [01:27:00] you know, and then there's, like, no capital. Like, after 20- the '21 boom, you had the '22 bust, and companies couldn't raise. Um, then, you know, we're, we were swinging the other direction. Um, and we don't know how far we're gonna go, but it's, you know, it's gonna get sillier. Um- I would just say that, you know, like I see valuations rising.

I, I-- At Astar, we're a pre-seed and seed-focused fund, um, and we-- so we're looking at the earliest of stages, and the valuations are higher than, mostly higher than I've ever seen. There's-

William Salvi: Where-- what's the typical range?

Kevin Hartz: Y- I, I mean, it's, that's very hard to say 'cause you could still, you can still find an investment and help a founder get started at a five million or 10 million post.

Um, but you have a foundational model company raising at, [01:28:00] you know, a five billion post or a performance computing company at a five billion post or an AV company at 15 billion post. These are all seed rounds. Um, so those are excessively high, but, um, they're not the majority. They're the, still the outliers.

Then you have, um, you know, w-where we are in the, the cycle, like I still see a lot of chip companies. I still see a lot of public movement of, of chips and the underlying side of the, you know, the AI revolution, and that's data centers, that's infrastructure, that's the different type of pipes connecting, and so on.

There's a big build-out happening there. Um, and that, that usually says we're early in the cycle. Uh, if you go back to the '90s, you had Intel and Cisco, um, really making great sales and, and booming as they built the [01:29:00] internet infrastructure. You needed like PCs, and you needed the pipes for, for the internet, and, and Intel and, and Cisco led that, and then Microsoft and others like kind of, uh, followed.

So all that says that maybe we're still early in the cycle. Then you look at the foundational model companies, Anthropic and OpenAI, and we're still really in like a one-hit wonder world of coding co-pilots. Like yes, without a doubt, there are other categories. We backed a business called Decagon, um, in the customer service area, and it's absolutely cranking.

Um, but really like if you look at the scale of the coding co-pilots, Cursor and CloudCode and Codex, they're off the charts, and that's just one category. Think of all the infinite number of categories that still need to be built. So that says we're early in the cycle. So there are these conflicting notes of, of, you know, okay, one category still working on the [01:30:00] infrastructure layer, but then on the other hand, valuations are off the charts at, in private and some public companies.

Julia Hartz: No notes

William Salvi: No notes. Mm-hmm. Well, I, I just got the cue from our team that we're over time. I had one more, one or two more questions, but I wanted to just say that, one, thank you for setting this up, 'cause your w- it was your willingness to do that.

Julia Hartz: You're awesome. Thanks for-

William Salvi: Thank you Thank you, Will ...

Kevin Hartz: like,

Julia Hartz: DM'ing with me.

William Salvi: Yeah, yeah. I, I- That's why social media's great, too, you know? There you go. And, um, but no, I, I really respect what you guys have done, and, um, I appreciate your time, so thank you so much. You guys are two founders that I think a lot of people should listen to.

Kevin Hartz: Was you- Well ... thank you, Will. You didn't DM me, which, like, the nerve here.

I w- I

William Salvi: d- so I, I friend requested you on Instagram I th- I think. Oh. And I'm going to after this. Oh, got it. But you, you, you know, Julia's a little more- Oh, who says? ... publicly facing- Yeah ... if you will. So I'll, I'll ... Just look out for a, a- Okay, thank you ... Instagram friend request. I have a

Julia Hartz: blue check mark. Do you have a blue check mark?

Kevin Hartz: Yeah, of course. Oh, cool.

William Salvi: Yeah. I'm gonna do it. If I didn't do [01:31:00] it, I'm gonna do it right after this. So I accept you. Thanks, man. I, I ... You better accept it and follow me back. Of

Kevin Hartz: course.

Julia Hartz: Thanks, Will.

William Salvi: Well, thank you so much. Appreciate you guys. Gotta go.

Julia Hartz: Yay. Yay. Good job. Man, you're good. Okay, you gotta check it.

You gotta check it now. Oh, no. Oh,

Other: is it there? Not bad. Not

Julia Hartz: bad? No. Not bad? Not at all.

Other: Okay.

Julia Hartz: Fine. So

Other: I got these-